

וַיְבָרֶךְ אֱלֹקִים אֶת יוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי וַיְקַדֵּשׁ אֹתוֹ כִּי בּו שְׁבֹת מְכַל מְלֹאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר בָּרָא אֱלֹקִים לַעֲשׂוֹת (2:3) The pasuk could have said כִּי בּו שְׁבֹת מְכַל מְלֹאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר בָּרָא אֱלֹקִים. What does the word לַעֲשׂוֹת add? רש"י says on the pasuk before הַשְּׁבִיעִי וַיְקַדֵּשׁ אֹתוֹ. מְנוּחָה - what was the world missing? The world was missing מְנוּחָה. He brings from the medrash בְּאֵת שְׁבֹת בָּאת מְנוּחָה, בְּאֵת שְׁבֹת בָּאת מְנוּחָה, חֶסֶד? מְנוּחָה, בְּאֵת שְׁבֹת בָּאת מְנוּחָה. An interesting concept. We think of מְנוּחָה as the absence of work. So how is it called a בְּרִיאָה? We have to redefine and reunderstand what the word מְנוּחָה means, vis-a-vis הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא. Now, we know that the שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִי בְּרֵאשִׁית are different from all the rest of history in that each and every day הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא created something which had not been there before, it's a Latin term, creatio ex nihilo, the term that we're more familiar with is יֵשׁ מֵאֵין. During שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִי בְּרֵאשִׁית, Hashem created מֵאֵין יֵשׁ all of the contents of the world which has never been there before.

Beginning with Shabbos, הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא recreates everything in the world each and every day, יֵשׁ מֵאֵין. All the סְפָרִים bring down that רַגַע causes the existence of all matter in this world. The exact opposite of Aristotle who said matter is eternal, we say that matter is הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא's creation each and every moment, and not only that, it's יֵשׁ מֵאֵין. Just because it was there before, the previous moment's existence is absolutely no reason for this matter, this particle of matter to be there the next second. Each and every moment, the world is being recreated. We say that in davening every single day, הַמְחִיד הַמְחִיד בְּטוֹבוֹ - הַקְדוּשׁ. What does that mean? הַמְחִיד בְּטוֹבוֹ - הַקְדוּשׁ. בְּטוֹבוֹ כָּל יוֹם תָּמִיד מַעֲשֵׂה בְּרֵאשִׁית. What does that mean? הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא in his goodness is newly creating; תָּמִיד - continuously; מַעֲשֵׂה בְּרֵאשִׁית. So שְׁבֹת, which we use as a symbol of resting, of stopping from work, is actually our עֵדוּת, is our testimony that הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא is the מַמְצִיא and the בּוֹרָא and continues its constant existence. As the בֵּית הַלֵּוִי, which this is from, says, we are used to seeing things continually existing because in our minds, in our eye, we see things being there on a constant basis. That's because we can't see it being recreated every second. הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא made it that way. In our mind and in our consciousness, that's called מְנוּחָה. That's called שְׁבֹת, it's called resting. Hashem is recreating the world every second - that is שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִי בְּרֵאשִׁית מְנוּחָה. was creating something which had never been there before - that's called בְּרִיאָה.

The בֵּית הַלֵּוִי is explaining that רש"י is saying that when Hashem made שְׁבֹת, it's a symbol of מְנוּחָה, that Hashem is actually the ongoing מְנוּחָה and



בורא העולם forever. That's what לַעֲשׂוֹת means - that Hashem's act of creation wasn't something finished, but something that continues; creation was made "לַעֲשׂוֹת", to be ongoing, constantly renewed. That is a tremendous concept. I understand the great גדולים knew this, appreciated it, and kept it in their minds constantly. We of a lesser stature have to be reminded of it at least once a year in פרשת בראשית. It's a good thing to remember. הקדוש ברוך הוא is the מקדש בטובו בכל יום תמיד מַעֲשֵׂה בְּרָאשִׁית. It's a great thing to be able to keep in mind, relearn, and emphasize.



זכות. Everybody's favorite פרשה. We love פרשת בראשית. I had the pleasure to hear the following vort from Zeidy Weiss, ע"ה, who was such a טייערער מענטש. He said this so sweetly that it was unforgettable, as many of the things that he did, and it's good to pass it along to you. He heard it in the name of R' Rosenzweig, the מרא דאתרא of the ישיבת ישיבת, and he heard it from R' Yoshe Ber Soloveitchik - that's a pretty impressive line of דאמירן.

The pasuk says (1:16) וַיַּעַשׂ אֱלֹהִים אֶת שְׁנֵי הַמָּאֹרֹת הַגְּדֹלִים - הַקֹּדֶשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא created the two great luminaries; אֶת הַמָּאֹר הַגָּדֹל לְמַשְׁכֵּל הַיּוֹם וְאֶת הַמָּאֹר הַקָּטָן לְמַמְשֶׁלֶת הַלַּיְלָה וְאֶת הַכּוֹכָבִים. R' Soloveitchik asked the following question on this pasuk: At a bris we say זֶה הַקָּטָן גָּדוֹל יִהְיֶה. It's a famous ברכה, that we want this little one to become big. So the obvious קושי is what kind of ברכה is that? It is the nature of things - he's a little kid, he's going to grow up. That's a ברכה? What is the intention of this ברכה? We should say he should become a פשוט - זֶה הַקָּטָן גָּדוֹל יִהְיֶה. What is the תלמיד חכם, צדיק, he should be a פשוט?

So the Rav refers to this pasuk, the two מָאֹרֹת הַגְּדֹלִים, the מָאֹר הַגָּדֹל, which is the sun, and the מָאֹר הַקָּטָן, which is the moon. We know that the sun illuminates on its own power. We know that the moon is simply a reflection of the light of the sun. So too each and every one of us. When we're young and learning and our parents are raising us and our רבנים, our teachers are teaching us, we are all receiving instruction, receiving חכמה, receiving תורה, receiving all the things we need to grow up properly and to stand on our own. As children, when we have light, it's a reflection of that which was instilled within us, the light reflecting off of the sun. That's a מָאֹר הַקָּטָן. In that ברכה, we daven that בעזרת השם we should get to a point in our lives when we're big enough that we will be able to illuminate on our own, a מָאֹר הַגָּדֹל, that we will take what we've gotten from our previous teachers and דורות and use that to start our own light, to instill within ourselves the ability to fire up our own light and to illuminate those around us and those who come after us. So it's a beautiful take on these words זֶה הַקָּטָן גָּדוֹל יִהְיֶה.

בעזרת השם, we should all have the זכות to illuminate all those around us.



פרשת בראשית, a new cycle for the year. The holy Yid of P'shischa was known to have great insight in the important things in life. One of the דברי מוסר that he had was that he advised people to always wear a jacket with pockets on both sides. He said that in the two pockets, he should have two different slips of paper. On one side he should have a piece of paper that says בשבילי נברא העולם. In the other pocket, he should have the phrase, אנכי עפר ואפר. I found an interesting parallel in פרשת בראשית.

Regarding שבת the pasuk says (2:2), וַיֵּשֶׁבֶת אֱלֹהִים בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מְלָאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה, וַיִּשְׁבֹּת. Completed his work on the seventh day, and he rested on the seventh day. The question is that there's a *סתירה* in the pasuk. It says that Hashem finished his work, and in the same pasuk it says וַיִּשְׁבֹּת - he rested from his work. Did Hashem work or did He rest? The answer that's always given is, and I'll quote it now verbatim from *מנחת חינוך* (1:10): בְּשֹׁר וְדָם שָׂאִינוּ יוֹדְעֵי לֹא עָתִיו וְלֹא רִגְעָיו וְלֹא שְׁעוֹתָיו, הוּא מוֹסִיף קוֹדֶשׁ, אֲבָל הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא יוֹדֵעַ רִגְעָיו וְעָתִיו וְשְׁעוֹתָיו, נִכְנָס בּוֹ כְּחוֹט הַשְּׁעָרָה - הוּא יוֹדֵעַ בְּרֹךְ הוּא knows precisely the way that time is running, Hashem created time, and therefore He knows exactly when שבת starts and when שבת ends. This *בראשית רבה* appears to be pointing out man's deficiencies, man's limited view of the world, man's inability to be as precise as הוּא בְּרֹךְ הוּא.

The *changes the meaning of this בראשית רבה* just a drop. To repeat: *בְּשֵׁר וְדָם שְׂאֵינוּ יוֹדֵעַ לֹא עֲתֵיו וְלֹא רִגְעָיו וְלֹא שְׁעוֹתָיו* - A man does not know his moments, his minutes, or his hours. The *מדרש* is telling us we have no control over our lives; we don't know how long our lives will last. We have no control at all over one of the most basic aspects of life, which is time. That is man's limitation. Look how little we are, look how imprecise we are, look how humble we should be because of this fact of knowing so little about even every moment of the day. That's what the *מדרש* is telling us. When *שבת* comes in, we should glorify and magnify *הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא*'s greatness as *מֶלֶךְ*, especially when we look at it from the point of view that we are unable to do that at all. So, *עפר ואפר*, the famous saying about *עפר* is dirt, it has no past. *אפר* is ashes, has no future. *אָבִינוּ* was saying, I have no past and no future. I am nothing. Therefore, if we recognize our humility and our true station in life, we will be better people.



Let's go to another pasuk. The pasuk says when הקדוש ברוך הוא was preparing to create אדם הראשון, he had a conference with the מלאכים. He said (1:26), נַעֲשֶׂה אָדָם בְּצַלְמֵנוּ כְּדִמוּתֵנוּ וְיִרְדּוּ בְדִגְתַּי הַיָּם וּבְעוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם וּבַבְּהֵמָה וּבְכָל הָאָרֶץ, וּבְכָל הָרֶמֶשׂ הָרֹמֵשׂ עַל הָאָרֶץ. In (ס' ע"ב) this pasuk is brought down with the following rather startling observation: - כִּי סִיִּים מְסַאֲגִיהַ - לִימָא: "כְּרוּךְ שְׁעֵשָׂה לִי כָּל צָרְכֵי"; Hashem, you have made for me all that I need. The וילנא גאון again asks, what do all of the things that we need have to do with putting on our shoes? Is the fact that we put on our shoes fulfilling all of our requests and our needs?

תהלים: תַּמְשִׁילָהוּ בְּמַעֲשֵׂי יְדִיד (8:7) האון answers with the famous pasuk in. Everything that is in creation is under man's dominion. The pasuk tells you that we have a הקדוש ברוך הוא שליטה. The pasuk gave Man the power to control the entire בריאה. We take a seed, we can crush it up, make it into food, or we can plant it and we can make it into many plants which we can eat or feed them to our בהמות. We can take the בהמה and we can שחט it. We can use the בהמה as food. We can use the בהמה as a source of milk. We can use the leather of the בהמה to make a shoe. Hashem gave us these opportunities to control the world. Man's purpose is to be שולט in the world for one reason and one reason only: because the הקדוש ברוך הוא said so. The הקדוש ברוך הוא says, you rule the world, we have to do that job as part of our responsibility that Hashem gives us.

The וילנא גאון has an amazing insight that he quotes from the sefer אמרי ממשלה. Why do we say לִי שְׁעֵשָׂה in לשון עבר, שְׁעֵשָׂה לִי כָּל צָרְכֵי? Because this rulership of the world, we already got this from בראשית. That's what the פרשה is telling us.

בשבילי נברא העולם. On the one hand, yes, אנכי עפר ואפר. But Hashem also told us that we rule the world. If we rule it properly, Hashem will let us continue ruling the world. It is our job, our function, in exactly the same way as it is our job to remain humble as we do it. Let's try to work on both of these things and see if we can pull it off. Not an easy task, but it's doable only because the Torah says so.



על פן יעזב איש את אביו ואת אמו וידבק (2:24) פרשת בראשית, we have the pasuk (2:24) בְּאִשְׁתּוֹ וְהָיוּ לְבָשָׂר אֶחָד, which is the basis of all of our שידוכים efforts, to fulfill this pasuk and bring שידוכים and זיווגים into the world. The following story, quoting from the Torah Tavlin, was recently told over by a יונגערמאן, married with three children. This story occurred when he was 27 years old.

The שידוך period was a real difficult one for him. It's not that he was overly picky, but the appropriate offers just didn't happen. The right date had just not come along. After so many offers that ended in nothing, one can easily reach despair.

What's more, two of his friends were married, and one of them already had a six-year-old child. "On one of the days of הזמנים", he says, "I went to בני ברק to attend the wedding of a friend. I arrived at the חופה, stayed for the food and dancing. At 10 o'clock, I left the hall for the nearest bus back to ירושלים. I met a friend and started talking to him at the entrance of a building. It turns out that he was at a שבע ברכות of his relative. Suddenly, a man comes down from the building and says to my friend, "Why are you out here? Come upstairs. It's really empty and sad up there." Then he turns to me, "Come upstairs, they're waiting for you there." "Waiting for me?" I asked? "Go upstairs?" "Waiting for what?" I tried to tell him that he's mixing me up with somebody else, but he interrupted me. "Look, I'm really looking for a man to complete our מנין for a שבע ברכות. So please, come upstairs. There's a חתן and כלה up there, they're supposed to be happy. It's already 10:30 p.m. and there are only six people there. If you go up, you'll get a prize." I opened my mouth to answer him that I'm in a hurry, and besides, I wasn't looking for a prize. But something in his voice sounded kind and innocent. I decided to comply.

"It was a basic שבע ברכות in a private home. It was also rather shabby, with the bride and groom, two in-laws, one grandfather, two boys, and several babies in strollers. No one sang or even spoke. No music was being played. It was quite נעבעכדיק, to be quite honest. I thought to myself, "How are they going to pass the time here?" Little by little, individual family members arrived, and finally, they had a מנין. The man who had called me looked and said to me, "Sing something." I looked to left, then to my right, and realized he was talking to me. I had no choice. I started עוד ישמע and ממהרה, and then lapsed into ענוי הגפן וענוי הגפן and ויזכו לבנות בית נאמן בישראל. A few members of the bride's family, it might have been the groom's family, who



knew, hummed along with me. This went on for a few moments. After these songs, the same man approached me and whispers in my ear, “Say a few words for the שמחה.” I looked at him. “I know you didn’t prepare a דבר תורה, but go ahead. Start to speak. Say something about the חתן. You will receive a prize.” Again with the prize. What does he want from me? The man told me that the חתן’s name was Mordechai, he learns in such-and-such ישיבה, his מסכתא, his ראש ישיבה, and a few other pertinent details. “Say a few words שמחה the לכבוד,” he again urged me.

“And so I acted bravely, got up and began to sing the praises of a man named Mordechai whom I had never in my life seen before and most likely would never see again. Somehow, a speech came out that was full of praise for the bridegroom, whose name I’d never heard a few minutes ago, who went far in his learning, עבודת השם, and in relation to his friends. I even gave examples from his life which I had heard a moment before, in which Mordechai proved himself to be noble and special in the מידה of giving. My words made a great impression on those present, and to be honest, myself too. I praised the wonderful חתן by saying that “This is what they say about him.” Everyone shook my hand, and the bridegroom embraced me with many thanks. No one stood up to speak after me. It seemed that my speech saved the שבע ברכות, which had almost shut down.

“The Yid sitting next to me asked for my name. He wanted to propose a שידוך. “How are you related to the groom?” he was interested. “I’m not related to the groom - or the bride,” I explained to him. “I don’t know anyone, I don’t even know the bride’s surname.” “So what are you doing here?” he asked. “חסד,” I told him. “I was asked to come and make the מנין.” He laughed heartily and said, “I am also a passerby who came here at the request of one of the relatives. Since we are both in the same family situation towards this חתן and כלה, that already makes us מחותנים, kind of.” He smiled kindly. “In short, I want to suggest to you my sister’s daughter,” “What makes you think of proposing your sister’s daughter before you even know me? I asked him. “To tell you the truth, after your special speech, I feel like I know you a little. After I hear that you were here voluntarily, I know you even more and appreciate you. Thirdly, why not give it a try?” Indeed, the third claim tipped the scales. I gave him my parents’ phone number and we went our separate ways.

“Everything else is already history. That evening produced a match, and today I am married with three children, ברוך השם. And why did I remember



this story? Because a week ago I met someone familiar on the bus. He looked at me and I looked at him. “I know you from somewhere,” he said. “Yeah, I recognize you too,” I answered him. We both looked at each other. We both knew each other, but we couldn’t remember from where. Suddenly he tapped his forehead. At that moment, I did the same. We both remembered. “It was you who spoke at the שבע ברכות of my brother, Muti, in בני ברק without even knowing him. How could I forget that? I have never heard such praise from someone who does not know the groom at all. It might have been the best שבע ברכות speech of all time. It was a sad evening that did not contribute to the happiness of the חתן and כלה, and you saved it with your appearance and your wonderful words and your act of חסד. I remember that very well.” We both laughed. “Wait, oy oy, hold on a second” he said suddenly. “What’s the matter”? I asked. “I promised you a prize, remember? One must keep his promise.” I laughed and said to the kind man, “Don’t worry, Hashem has kept your promise, I received my prize.”





Parshas Noach. All the בעלי מדרש have said numerous times that everything needs to have מזל, even ספר תורה בהיכלא מזל. The מזל about חומש is that the first pasuk in every parsha has millions of מדרשים on it, and the later pesukim in the parsha are not discussed as intensively. So in פרשת נח, guess who we're going to talk about? Not what you expected, we're going to talk about אברהם אבינו.

It says at the very end of the parsha that אברהם אבינו comes from תרה (11:27): תרה הוליד את אברהם את נחור ואת הרן. Who is הרן? הרן was אברהם אבינו's brother. It also mentions that הרן died in תרה על פני תרה (11:28) וקמת הרן על פני תרה. Rashi says that הרן died before his father died. Why did he die?

Another question is that one of our famous stories about אברהם אבינו is אור כשדים. Where is that in the תורה? Ain't nowhere in the תורה. It's in this Rashi at the end of אברהם אבינו נח. אברהם would not bow down to שמו. So Nimrod said "I'm throwing you into the fire." But as he was going into the fire and was being saved, they asked הרן, "Who are you with? Are you with נמרוד or are you with אברם?" He said "Let me see what happens." When he saw that אברם was saved, he said, "I'm with אברם". They threw him into the fire and he wasn't saved as he was doing it אברהם אבינו. לשמה did it שלא לשמה. So the whole מדרש אור כשדים, upon which we start our whole narrative of אברהם אבינו, who he was and what he represented, which was מסירות נפש and קידוש שם שמים, is in Rashi at the end of נח. Not in לך לך, certainly not in וירא or חיי שרה. So now we know who אברם is. Thank you Rashi, and thank you the pasuk, because Rashi is explaining the pasuk, of course. But it's buried here. It's buried here for a very simple reason.

Every nation in the world glorifies itself on its independence. America has July 4th, the French have their day, July 14th. The Mexicans have José de Martín. Every nation, even the Russians ימה שם, even the Ukrainians, certainly the French, everybody is always proud of their heritage, of their independence and their Bastille Day, their starting out as great nations. And what do we do? We start out with, as we say about the haggadah, מתחילין בשבח. So we say זרה היו אבותינו בגנות ומסיימין בשבח. We started out little. We never claim our independence. We say הקדוש ברוך הוא took us out of מצרים, no one else. הקדוש ברוך הוא is the one who's responsible for our independence, not us. In exactly the same way, אברהם אבינו's great brilliance, fantastic מסירות נפש to start off our history as a nation is also buried. It's very hidden. We have to go and uncover it and search for it. Like everything else



in this world, אמת is hidden; שקר is all over the place. Our אמת is buried there. We have to look for it, and when we look for it we'll actually appreciate it more because we have to put in the effort to find it.

פרשת נח's glorious beginning is hidden at the end of נח. Hidden at the end of the parsha where nobody is looking. Everybody's looking at how wonderful נח is. And yet אברהם אבינו surpassed him in so many ways. We're not בני נח, we're בני אברהם, יצחק ויעקב. And בעזרת השם, in that זכות, may we be ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו אמן to זוכה.

